

MEDICAL MISSIONS IN KISIIZI, UGANDA

WHEN WHAT WE HAVE ISN'T ENOUGH



AUGUST/SEPTEMBER 2026 REPORT
LEAH PRAIRIE

I'm Back!

One evening not long after returning to Kisiizi, I left the front door of my little house open. A few minutes later, I looked up to find a goat standing inside!

This was not particularly unusual by Kisiizi standards, but it did make me laugh. Apparently, after being away for seven months, I had forgotten one of the important rules of life here: if you leave the door open, you should probably expect visitors.

Since coming back, that has been true in more ways than one.

My house has become a place where people come and go. A baby who was abandoned and is now being cared for by the hospital spends many of my days off with me. Neighbours stop by. Friends from fellowship groups come to visit. Colleagues finishing a late shift at the hospital sometimes arrive hungry and decide that my kitchen is easier than going home to cook. And apparently, this invitation extends to goats as well.

It is one of the things I love about life here. There is a sense that you do not have to make an appointment to be part of one another's lives. People simply show up.

And after seven months away, it has been good to have people showing up again. To be welcomed back so warmly into a community whose language and culture I am still learning to understand.



MY LITTLE VISITORS



AFTERNOON HIKES



MY LIVING ROOM

So, Where Exactly Am I?

For those who may be new to my updates, I am back in Kisiizi, Uganda, serving as a nurse at Kisiizi Hospital. I work alongside Ugandan nurses, doctors, students, and other staff, caring for patients primarily on the paediatric and medical wards. My days also include teaching, small research and quality-improvement projects, hospital communications, and plenty of opportunities to become involved in the life of the community beyond the hospital walls.

I first came to Kisiizi for a shorter season of service, but somewhere along the way, this little mountain community began to feel like home. After my second visit, I sensed God leading me back for something longer. So, in June, I returned to begin a three-year season of volunteer service.

I knew coming back would bring challenges. I expected the long days, the unfamiliar cases, the language learning, and the occasional goat-related inconvenience. What I didn't quite anticipate was how often I would be reminded that what I have is not always enough.

Because here, as in so many places, the need is often greater than what we have to give.



When There Isn't Enough

One of the things I have been reminded of very quickly since coming back is just how much need there is here.

Kisiizi has earned itself a reputation for helping people who are struggling. Whether someone is sick, facing a difficult pregnancy, unable to afford the care they need, or simply arrives at the hospital in a desperate situation, there is a strong desire to find a way to help. It is one of the things I admire most about this place.



But being known as a place that will help also comes with its own challenges. The hospital has limited resources, and the needs are certainly not limited. There are patients who genuinely cannot afford everything they need, and there are also times when people who could contribute toward their care know that Kisiizi is unlikely to simply turn them away. It can make decisions about financial assistance complicated.

How do you remain generous without making promises you cannot keep? How do you steward what has been entrusted to the hospital when you know there will always be another person waiting who needs help?

These are not abstract questions here. They are part of everyday hospital life.

Sometimes the limitation is money. Sometimes it is equipment. Sometimes it is time or staff. Sometimes you are working through a clinical problem and the option you would normally reach for simply isn't available. You look at what you have and realize that it isn't everything you would like to have.

And I have found myself thinking about that phrase quite a lot since coming back: **It isn't enough.**





I think I am particularly aware of it because I am aware of my own limitations, too. There are things I don't know. There are situations I cannot fix. There are patients I cannot make well simply because I wish I could. There are days when I am tired, my Rukiga is nowhere near where I want it to be, and I am very conscious that I am trying to do my best with what I have.

But perhaps that is exactly where faith begins to shine the brightest.

The Bible is full of people who were asked to do something with what they had, even when what they had didn't seem like enough. Moses had a staff. David had a sling. A widow had a little oil. And a crowd of thousands had five loaves and two fish.

The disciples looked at what they had and knew it wasn't enough. But Jesus wasn't asking them to have enough. He was asking them to bring what they had.

He also asks me to do the same. He sees me when my mind is tired, my hands are weak, and my kitchen is empty. And when I think I have given my all, He comes along and gently adds something else. He reminds me that even what I have to offer comes from His hands.



Learning to Rest

One of the things God has been showing me since coming back is that if I want to pour into other people, I also need to learn how to be filled.

Life here can be quite full. My mornings often begin with chapel before heading into clinical work in the Emergency Department. In between patients and shifts, there are research projects to help with, children to care for, Sunday school to prepare, meals to cook, people to visit, and all the ordinary things that somehow fill up the hours of a day. I enjoy being busy. I enjoy having people around. I enjoy feeling useful.

But I am learning that I cannot continually pour out without first taking time to be filled myself. Jesus Himself withdrew to quiet places. He prayed. He spent time with His Father. If I want to keep giving to the people around me, I need to learn to do the same.

Sometimes it means taking a nap in the afternoon because I am tired. Sometimes it means sitting on my front steps with a novel and letting the to-do list wait. Sometimes it means going for a walk simply because it is beautiful outside. And sometimes it means taking a little trip into town to stay with a friend, eating ice cream, and remembering that life is not only about getting things done.

I am slowly learning that these things are not interruptions to the work God has given me. They are part of how He cares for me.

Perhaps this is another part of what the five loaves and two fish have been teaching me. Jesus did not ask the disciples to bring something they didn't have.



"Then he ordered the crowds to sit down on the grass, and taking the five loaves and the two fish, he looked up to heaven and said a blessing. Then he broke the loaves and gave them to the disciples, and the disciples gave them to the crowds. And they all ate and were satisfied."

- Matthew 14:20

A Little Blessing

There is a little boy in our nursery named Blessing who has become a regular part of my days. He is nearly four months old, and his story is difficult to imagine. Shortly after he was born, he was found abandoned by a Good Samaritan. Against all odds, he survived and was brought to Kisiizi. The medical team struggled to provide all the care he needed. He was so sick when he arrived that many doubted he would survive a few days, much less a few months. He needed strong antibiotics, platelet transfusions, and constant monitoring.

His circumstances remain complicated, and there are still many unanswered questions about his family and what his future will look like. But for now, he is safe, growing, and very much loved by the people caring for him.

He has also become a regular companion on my days and nights after clinical work. Some days he comes home with me, where he eats, sleeps, gets cuddled, and generally takes over the house. I have to admit, I am quite happy to let him.

His story could have ended very differently. I am grateful it didn't.



"Let love be genuine. Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good. Love one another with brotherly affection. Outdo one another in showing honour. Do not be slothful in zeal, be fervent in spirit, serve the Lord. Rejoice in hope, be patient in tribulation, be constant in prayer. Contribute to the needs of the saints and seek to show hospitality.

-Romans 12:9-13

Thank You for Helping Me Be Here

When I began preparing to return to Kisiizi for three years, I wasn't sure how the financial side would come together. I am incredibly grateful that, through the generosity of so many people, I now have 33 monthly financial partners and have surpassed my original pre-departure fundraising goal.

This support has given me greater stability as I settle into life here, particularly while navigating things like work permit delays and the unexpected costs that come with living overseas. It has also given me the freedom to respond to needs around me, from helping provide diapers, clothing, formula and other necessities for baby Blessing to supporting a close friend and young mother of two who recently lost her husband.

I am deeply grateful to everyone who has made this possible. Your generosity has allowed me not only to be here, but to have something to share when a need arises.

While I have surpassed my initial goal, new monthly partners are still very welcome. Ongoing support helps make this three-year commitment sustainable and gives me the flexibility to respond to needs as they arise.

Thank you for being part of this with me.



You Can Be Part of This Too

Financial support is only one way to participate in what God is doing here.

Prayer is one of the greatest gifts you can give me. Pray for wisdom as I work clinically, for the patients and families I encounter, for my relationships with colleagues and friends, and for the many little decisions that make up daily life here.

And please don't underestimate the encouragement of a little message from home. A WhatsApp message telling me about something ordinary that happened in your day, a picture of maple trees or snow when I am missing Canada, a verse that came to mind, or simply a “thinking of you” can mean more than you probably realize.

You don't need to have something profound to say. Sometimes it is just nice to hear from home...

Thank you for continuing to follow along with this little corner of my life in Uganda. There is still so much I am learning, and I am sure there will be plenty more stories to come, some meaningful, some difficult, and probably quite a few involving goats.

I am grateful to have you along for the journey.

With love and gratitude,
Leah







Leah Prairie

Registered Nurse & Public Health Practitioner
RN, BN, MScPH

prairieleah@gmail.com
+256 773 024 894